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Adolescent Stress: Causes, Impact, and Coping Strategies

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Abstract
Adolescence is a developmental stage known for its physical, psychological, and social transformations, It is frequently accompanied by elevated stress levels. In this review paper the causes, effects, and coping strategies of stress in adolescents are examined. This study offers practical methods for managing adolescent stress and encouraging healthy ageing by identifying stressors and their impacts on mental and physical health. Stressors associated with growing up and becoming an adult include peer relationships, parental expectations, social media influences, and academic pressure. High level of stress can have major negative impacts on one's mental and physical health; it leads to anxiety, despair, and risky behaviour in adolescents. This paper incorporates recent research findings to comprehensively understand this significant topic through an analysis of the causes, consequences, and coping strategies related to adolescent stress. Adolescence is a crucial developmental period that is marked by changes in the body, emotions, and mind. As a person grows from childhood to adulthood numerous stressors come up such as academic pressure, peer pressure, familial expectations and social media effects. High level of stress can result in, dangerous behaviours depression, anxiety and other serious effects on one's physical and mental health. This paper examined the causes, effects, and coping mechanisms of adolescents' stress, which incorporates new research findings to offer a thorough grasp of this important topic.

Keywords: Adolescents stress, causes, impact, coping strategies

1. Introduction

Adolescence is a significant stage of physical, emotional, and intellectual development, as well as significant changes in society (Petersen, 2021) [32]. While these changes are important for the development of identity and independence, they often cause problems for young peoples 'mental health. The pressures experienced during this time are many; these include the strong need for academic achievement, the difficulty of social adjustment, and the challenge of finding one's own identity (Belcher *et al*., 2021) [4]. Modern influences such as global media add to these challenges by bringing constant comparison, fear of missing out, and the pressure to get the best online photos (McCrory *et al*., 2022) [23]. These stressors, when combined with typical developmental issues, put adolescents at high risk for mental health problems such as anxiety, depression, and low self-esteem. Understanding the history of these stressors and their impact on mental health is crucial for creating effective strategies and solutions (Auttama *et al*., 2022) [3]. This understanding not only help adolescents manage stress; but also provide techniques to build resilience and adaptability when they face future challenges. According to Sawyer *et al*. (2018) [37], adolescence is a period of transition between childhood and adulthood marked by rapid changes in cognitive, physical, social, and emotional domains. If these changes are not properly addressed then, they frequently cause stress, which can lead to constant issues with one's physical and mental health. Adolescents experience stress for a variety of reasons, such as peer relationships, family issues, cultural challenges, and academic expectations. In order to create effective coping strategies, it is necessary to recognize the causes and effects of adolescent stress.

1.1 Objectives

1. To identify causes of stress in adolescents.
2. To identify the impact of stress on adolescents.
3. To provide different stress management strategies for adolescents..

1.2 Methodology
The literature review strategy involved a comprehensive approach to identify relevant studies on causes, impact, and stress management strategies for adolescents. The data has been taken from various sources like research articles, journals, review papers, etc.

2. Causes of Adolescent Stress
Adolescents encounter stress from various sources. Key causes are depicted in Fig.1 and described below:

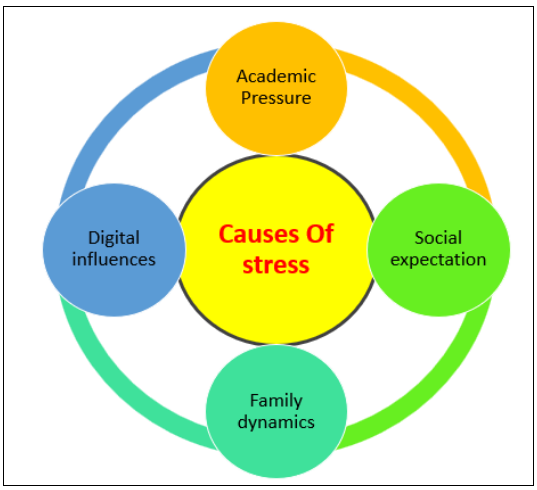

Fig 1: Causes of Adolescent Stress

2.1 Academic Pressure: Academic pressure is one of the main causes of stress in adolescents. The pressure to fulfil expectations of parents and teachers, to perform well on exams, and ensure a bright future frequently leads to stress and burnout**.** A major source of stress for adolescents is academic expectations and competition for admission to high schools and colleges which can be overwhelming as documented in previous studies (Luthar *et al*.,2020) [21]. One of the most frequent causes of stress among adolescents is pressure from school, it is further increased by building up pressure to excel in competitive exams, tests and professional aspirations (Deb *et al*., 2015) [11]. Anxiety and burnout are the results of adolescents' stage that creates imbalance in their personal lives, extracurricular activities, and schoolwork.

2.2 Social Expectations and Peer Pressure: During adolescence, social connections are essential. Peer pressure, friendship issues, and romantic relationship problems are common sources of stress. Adolescents may feel pressure to follow group principles, even if they violate their personal beliefs. Peer pressure is crucial in adolescents' decision-making processes that can result in risk-taking behaviours and it increase stress levels in adolescents (Prinstein and Giletta, 2016) [33]. Many adolescents feel pressure to adjust with their peers and experiencing stress about appearance lifestyle choices, and popularity (Papageorgiou *et al*.,2022). Bullying, peer pressure, and the need to adjust can cause mental pain, risky behaviours and low self- esteem. Making friendships, peer approval and social interactions can be a major source of stress in adolescents (Prinstein and Giletta, 2016) [33].

2.3 Family Dynamics: Conflicts within the family or pressure to meet parental expectations can lead to considerable stress (Jiang *et al*.,2022) [16]. The dynamics of the family are a great aspect in adolescent's stress. According to Sirin *et al*. (2016) [39], High parental expectations, family disputes and lack of communication can result in emotional distress. Adolescents experience higher levels of stress who are from broken family or those who are going through parental divorce.

2.4 Identity Formation and Self-Esteem
Individuals struggle with identity formation and issues related to self-esteem during this age. Concerns about one's own value, physical appearance, and future goals can lead to internal stress, particularly when combined with principles promoted by society and the media.

Erikson's psychosocial theory discovers "identity vs. role confusion" as a major adolescent struggle (Erikson, 1968) [12], emphasizing the psychological stress caused by identity exploration.

2.5 Digital Influences: Growing usage of social media caused digital stress in adolescents. Fear of missing out (FOMO), online comparison, cyberbullying, and the need to maintain a digital persona can all cause anxiety in adolescents. Social media usage has been linked to stress, as adolescents are exposed to cyberbullying and often develop unrealistic expectations based on curated content (Ajewumi *et al*., 2024) [1]. According to Keles *et al*. (2020) [17], adolescents who use social media more regularly are more likely to experience stress and anxiety due to ongoing social comparison, unattainable beauty standards, and cyberbullying. The pressure to maintain a well-curated online presence may lead to emotional exhaustion and issues with self-esteem. Orben *et al*. (2019), found a significant correlation between digital media use and mental health problems, especially among female adolescents. Hormonal changes in adolescents allow them to control their emotions and mood.

2.6 Biological and Hormonal Changes: These changes can make adolescents more vulnerable to stress, particularly if they struggle to understand and manage their emotions. According to Casey *et al*. (2010) [6], these neurobiological changes during adolescence increase emotional sensitivity and prolong stress reactions.

2.7 Social and Economic Difficulties: Social stigma, limited access to resources, and financial instability are additional stressors that often affect adolescents from low-income families or marginalized communities. According to Evans and Cassells (2014) [13], Adolescents' cognitive and emotional development affects negatively through ongoing stress linked to poverty. A complex interaction of biological, social, familial, academic, and environmental factors caused stress in adolescents. Parents, teachers, and mental health professionals must understand these issues in order to provide appropriate support and solutions.

3. Impact of Stress on Adolescents
Adolescents face many changes in their social, mental, and physical life during this age. During this age stress might lead to major issues that endure a long time. Peer pressure, familial problems, educational pressures, or personal concerns are the main causes of stress in adolescents and it affect all aspects of an adolescent's life.

3.1 Effects on the Mind and Emotions: Adolescents stress is related to various mental and emotional problems, like anxiety, depression, low self-esteem and mood swings. According to studies adolescents, who experience regular stress that has been suffered from mental health issues like major depressive disorder and generalised anxiety disorder. According to studies, adolescents who experience regular stress often show signs like restlessness, impatience, or long-term depression.

3.2 Effects on Academic Performance and Cognitive Function: Adolescents who are experience more stress face challenges to think properly, particularly regarding to memory, concentration, and decisions. This can affect their academic performance and motivation. Excessive stress produces high level of cortisol that can harm the hippocampus, a brain part involved in memory and learning (Lupien *et al*., 2009) [20]. Students, who experience more stress struggle with focus, problem-solving, and academic success (Deb *et al*., 2015) [11]. Long-term stress can cause academic difficulties, social withdrawal and dangerous habits like substance use. Adolescents who experience more stress it can also lead to self-harm and alcohol addiction.

3.3 Implications for Physical Health: Stress can show up physically, causing headaches, sleep problems, and weakened immunity (Chu *et al*., 2024) [8]. It reduces immunity, making it easier to get sick. Stress is also associated to headaches, tension, stomach issues, and sleep difficulties (Romeo, 2017) [34]. Adolescents who are under stress may develop harmful behaviours, such as substance abuse or poor diet, which can lead to eating disorders or obesity.

The body can suffer from stress, leading to headaches, stomach pain, exhaustion, and sleep problems. Stress triggers the HPA axis, which controls the body's response to stress and can harm the immune system if overactive (McEwen, 2006). Adolescents under stress often also have sleep issues and unhealthy eating habits (Owens *et al*., 2017) [29].

3.4 Behavioural Problems and Taking Chances: Adolescents who are under stress are more likely to use unhealthy coping strategies like substance use or social withdrawal. Adolescents who are more stressed are more susceptible to peer pressure, which can lead to harmful activities like drug use, unprotected sex, or careless driving (Prinstein and Giletta, 2016) [33]. These actions may provide short-term relief but can increase stress and cause serious chronic issues.

3.5 Relationships and Social Functioning: Stress can negatively affect social skills and relationship. " Adolescents who experience more stress may engage in arguments, act out, or detach themselves from peers. According to La Greca and Harrison (2005) [19], Adolescents who experience rejection or bullying by peers that leads to social stress, which can cause anxiety and feelings of loneliness.

3.6 Long-Term Developmental Effects: Adolescents who are under stress may experience mental health issues and delay in the development throughout adulthood. Adolescents who experience long-term stress, it leads to substance abuse, chronic diseases and mental illness, later in life (Felitti *et al*., 1998) [14]. Adolescent stress might affect a person's general health eventually. There are numerous effects of stress on adolescents' behaviour, social development, physical health, emotions, and thought processes. Stress can hinder with healthy growth and have long-term impacts in the absence of appropriate assistance and coping mechanisms. It requires early intervention, supportive surroundings, and stress-reduction techniques to protect the health of teenagers.

4.Coping Strategies

Academic responsibilities, social pressures, identity problems and hormonal changes lead to stress in adolescents. At this stage, it's critical to manage stress to protect mental health and prevent harmful effects. The following strategies can help adolescents to manage stress more effectively.

4.1 Cognitive-Behavioural Therapy (CBT) Techniques: CBT help adolescents in recognising and transforming negative thought patterns. It teaches adolescents to challenge harmful beliefs and create more effective coping mechanisms. CBT enhances emotional regulation and problem-solving skills, which helps with anxiety and depression.

For example, engaging in a 10-minute guided meditation or practicing mindful breathing might help lower tension and increase focus.

4.2 Exercise and Physical Activity

Doing exercise often helps to reduce stress. It makes your body to release endorphins, which are chemicals that make you feel-good and reduce stress hormones. Adolescents can play team sports, do yoga, or even take regular walks to feel better and manage stress. According to the Centres for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC, 2022), young people should engage in moderate-to-intense physical activities for at least 60 minutes each day to maintain the health of their bodies and minds.

4.3 Setting Goals and Managing Time:

If adolescents learn how to set goals and manage their time, they can be more productive and feel less stressed (Zimmerman, 2002) [44]. Adolescents can better balance school work, extra activities, and free time, if they are good at managing time, it helps reduce stress from last-minute problems. For example, planning study time and breaks in a weekly planner can help avoid getting tired and putting things off. According to research by Misra and McKean (2000) [26], students experience less stress and do better academically, who are good at managing their time.

4.4 Social Support Systems

Having good relations with family, friends and teachers give support and comfort during tough times. These relations have the potential to lessen the negative consequences of stress and increase resilience. For example, talking to a friend or family members about a difficult situation can give new ideas and a sense of being understood. Research shows that adolescents with high levels of social support experience lower levels of stress and sadness (Rueger *et al*., 2016) [35].

4.5 Mindfulness Techniques: Teenagers can learn to regulate their emotions by practicing deep breathing and meditation (Broderick, 2021) [5]. Yoga and mindful writing are two techniques that can help lower stress levels.

4.6 Limiting Social Media Use

Encouraging adolescents to spend more time offline and take breaks from social media can help improve their mental health and reduce stress. Parents are crucial, to observe their teenagers' screen time and encourage responsible technology use.

Through hobbies like drama, art, singing, and journaling, adolescents can release tension and express their emotions in a healthy way. For example, A student who enjoys drawing or sketching, can utilise art journaling to communicate depressive or anxious feelings. Research by Stuckey and Nobel (2010) [40] indicates that creative activities can improve mood, reduce stress and help mental health.

4.7 Healthy Lifestyle Choices

Getting enough sleep, eating well, and staying hydrated are important for managing stress. Poor habits can make stress more severe and emotions more unstable. For example, adolescents who have a regular sleep schedule and avoid coffee at night feel happier and handle stress better. According to Owens *et al*. (2017) [29], adolescents who sleep regularly experience less stress and do better in school.

4.8 School-Based Programs

School programs that help reduce stress often focus on teaching coping skills, stress management, and mental health education. These programs may include support groups, cognitive-behavioural techniques, mindfulness, and relaxation methods. Some schools also use wellness centres to offer activities like yoga and exercise. According to Hoover and Bostic (2021) [15], schools are crucial because they provide mental health support, stress management techniques, and therapy.

5. Conclusion

Stress in adolescents is caused by both external influences and personal growth. By identifying the causes of stress and employing practical coping mechanisms, adolescents can lessen negative consequences and make a smooth transition into adulthood. Further research into specific programs might improve coping methods and help adolescents' mental health. Adolescents' stress is influenced by social, family, academic, and digital factors. Too much stress without proper handling can harm both physical and mental health. On the other hand, effective coping strategies like managing time, having strong support, using cognitive techniques, and adopting healthy habits can lessen these effects. Parents, teachers, and mental health professionals should work together to create support systems that help adolescents build resilience and feel well.

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